Lab 04: Mood Board from a Real Brief

Level: Foundation Suggested time: 75 minutes Platform: Complete the core brief in either Procreate or Sketchbook Studio; use the comparison notes to transfer the workflow. Alignment: K2 | K3 | A1 | LO1

Scenario

A wellness pop-up requests a calm but energetic launch illustration for working adults.

Your role: Visual concept designer Required deliverable: An annotated mood board, three thumbnails and one selected direction.

Learning goal

Apply Brief analysis | audience | sensory cues | palette | thumbnail composition to a real design decision and produce evidence that meets explicit acceptance criteria.

Before you begin

- Use an iPad that supports your chosen app and a compatible stylus where available.
- Save an editable, layered master before exporting a flattened image.
- Use only owned, licensed or clearly permitted reference images and record their sources.
- Create a folder named Lab-04-<YourName> for working files and evidence.

Part A - Plan and construct

1. Underline the brief's audience, need, mood, constraints and success criteria.
2. Rewrite calm but energetic as observable cues: quiet space, stable rhythm and one warm accent.
3. Collect 9-12 owned, licensed or rights-safe references; record creator/licence/link.
4. Arrange references into palette, form, texture and exclusion groups; annotate why each belongs.
5. Create three genuinely different thumbnails by changing focal point, scale and movement.
6. Score each thumbnail against clarity, sensory fit, feasibility and originality.
7. Select one direction, document the trade-off, and export the board plus thumbnails.

Part B - Procreate pathway

1. Create a canvas or Page Assist document sized for the mood board.
2. Insert rights-safe references on separate layers and transform/crop without distorting them.
3. Use the Colour panel to sample candidates into a named palette, then reduce it to dominant/support/accent roles.
4. Use text layers only for concise annotations; keep source details in notes or the lab document.
5. Create thumbnails on a separate layer group with a simple opaque brush.
6. Duplicate the leading thumbnail before combining its strongest features with another.
7. Export a PDF or PNG board and retain the layered master.

Part C - Sketchbook Studio pathway

1. Choose a Grid or Blank page template to structure the board.

2. Import each rights-safe reference as an adjustable-opacity overlay or layer.
3. Arrange references using duplicate/reorder controls; keep one visual family per region.
4. Build colour swatches with the full colour picker and opacity control.
5. Create thumbnail sketches on a dedicated layer using Pencil or Monoline.
6. Duplicate the selected thumbnail before combining ideas.
7. Save on-device and export the annotated board as an image/PDF through the available share path.

Evidence and acceptance checklist

[ ] Every reference maps to a brief criterion

[ ] At least three genuinely different thumbnails

[ ] Palette has dominant/support/accent roles

[ ] Selection rationale names trade-offs

[ ] Layered working file is saved and opens correctly.

[ ] Final export uses a clear filename and matches the intended dimensions.

[ ] At least one in-progress screenshot shows the technique in use.

[ ] Reference sources and design decisions are recorded.

Peer review questions

1. Which cue implies calm without becoming sleepy?
2. What was excluded from the direction?
3. How could a non-visual cue be made more legible?

Debrief

Use the Observe → Interpret → Connect → Propose pattern:

1. Observe: State what is visible without praise or blame.
2. Interpret: Explain the likely effect on attention, meaning, emotion or use.
3. Connect: Link the effect to the brief, a design principle or the acceptance criteria.
4. Propose: Name one specific change and how you will check whether it works.

Record one decision you will keep, one change you will test, and one technique you can transfer to the other app.

Troubleshooting

- The line feels wobbly: Zoom out, slow the decision rather than the stroke, use shoulder movement, and increase stabilisation only enough to preserve intent.
- Colour leaks during fill: Close the contour, inspect gaps at 100%, or place colour on a separate layer and clean with the precise eraser.
- The file becomes hard to edit: Name or document layer roles, hide unused experiments, group related stages and duplicate before merging or filtering.
- The image looks muddy: Check value grouping, lower overlay opacity, remove competing texture and restore one clear focal contrast.

- Perspective feels wrong: Return to horizon and vanishing logic; correct the large box before windows, props or decoration.

Submission package

Submit Lab-04-<YourName>/ containing:

- layered working file (or the app's saved layered sketch);
- final PNG/JPEG/PDF as required by the brief;
- progress evidence/contact sheet;
- short design rationale answering the peer-review questions; and
- reference/provenance list.

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